HACKTOBERFEST

STUDENT RULEBOOK

# Hacktoberfest x MOSS Hack Day Udupi

AB4, Rooms 501–504, MIT Manipal campus

Sunday, 25 October 2026 · 9:00 AM to 7:30 PM IST

These are the rules for every participant at Hacktoberfest x MOSS Hack Day Udupi on Sunday, 25 October 2026. Read them before you arrive, and ask any organizer if something is unclear.

**EVENT AT A GLANCE**

Hacktoberfest x MOSS Hack Day Udupi is a free, full-day, in-person MLH Hacktoberfest mini-hackathon hosted by Manipal Open Source Society. Student teams build with open-source and open-weight AI.

**CHALLENGES**

Best Open-Source AI Project; Best Use of Gemma 4

**PRIZES**

Gift cards worth up to $200 and 4 × Arduino UNO Q, plus DEV Badges for the open-source AI winners

**WHEN**

Sunday, 25 October 2026, 9:00 AM to 7:30 PM IST

**COST**

Free. No ticket, entry, membership or participation fee

## 01 Event Schedule

All times are IST on Sunday, 25 October. Submissions close at 5:00 PM sharp.

| | |
|---|---|
| 9:00–10:00 AM | Inauguration and introduction to the event; check in at the desk with your student ID |
| 10:00 AM | Hackathon begins; build time starts |
| 1:00–2:00 PM | Refreshments, served while you keep building |
| 5:00 PM | **Final call for submissions; submissions close** |
| 5:00–6:30 PM | Evaluation and results |
| 6:30–7:30 PM | Prize distribution |

## 02 Who can participate

This event is for students aged 18 or over, and it is free.

- You must be 18 or older on 25 October 2026. Bring your student ID, because organizers may check your student status and age at check-in.
- Register individually on the OrganizerHQ event page with your own MLH account, even if your team signs up together. Use the same account later to submit your project.
- Check in at the venue in person. Registering, or checking in online or in advance, does not count as attending.

### TEAMS

- Teams have 2 to 4 people. Solo entries are not allowed.
- Every team member must register individually and check in.
- Each person joins one team, and each team builds one project.

## 03 Code of Conduct and safety

Everyone at the event follows the **MLH Code of Conduct**, including organizers, judges, mentors, volunteers and sponsors. Harassment and abuse are never tolerated.

- The Code applies throughout the venue, at every event activity, and in online spaces connected to the event.
- Harassment covers offensive comments about who someone is, sexual images, intimidation, stalking, doxxing, harassing photos or recordings, disrupting talks, unwelcome physical contact and unwelcome sexual attention.
- Sexualized images or material are not allowed in projects or at the event.
- If someone asks you to stop, stop immediately.
- Consequences range from a warning to removal from the event and disqualification.

### HOW TO REPORT A CONCERN

**REPORT** Tell any one of the organizers about the concern. You can also contact MLH's incident team directly, and you may stay anonymous.

| REGION | PHONE | EMAIL |
|---|---|---|
| **India** | 000 80004 02492 | incidents@mlh.io |
| **Asia-Pacific** | +91 000 80004 02492 | incidents@mlh.io |
| **North America** | +1 409 202 6060 | incidents@mlh.io |
| **UK** | +44 800 808 5675 | incidents@mlh.io |
| **Europe** | +44 333 038 5995 | incidents@mlh.io |
| **Canada** | +1 343 453 4532 | incidents@mlh.io |

## 04 Challenges and prizes

This event runs two challenges: Best Open-Source AI Project and Best Use of Gemma 4. One project can enter both if it meets both sets of requirements.

### BEST OPEN-SOURCE AI PROJECT

Build an original project where open-source or open-weight AI is an important part of how it works. Examples, which you can combine: an agent skill, a project built on an open-weight small or large language model, or a new or improved open-source model harness.

#### REQUIREMENTS

- Open-source or open-weight AI is an important part of the project.
- The code is in a public GitHub repository with an open-source license, such as MIT, Apache-2.0, GPL-3.0 or another **OSI-approved license**.
- An agent skill follows the **Agent Skills open standard**.
- A model-harness entry is either an original implementation or a meaningful change to an existing open-source harness, such as OpenCode, Hermes Agent, OpenClaw or Pi.

#### TERMS USED IN THIS CHALLENGE

- **Open-weight model:** the trained weights can be downloaded or run under the provider's terms. Name the model and link its license or terms in your README.
- **Small or large language model:** small means 10 billion parameters or fewer; large means more than 10 billion.
- **Agent skill:** a reusable set of instructions and supporting files that follows the Agent Skills standard.
- **Model harness:** the software around a model that manages prompts, tools, memory, context and actions.

**PRIZE** One winning team. Each team member from the winning team receives a gift card and an Arduino UNO Q, so the team gets 2 to 4 of each, one per member present. Every member also receives a DEV Badge on their DEV account.

### BEST USE OF GEMMA 4



Build something with Gemma 4, Google's family of lightweight open-weight models, through the Gemini API. Make use of its multimodal capabilities: for example, an assistant that understands both text and images, or a focused AI tool for learning, creativity, productivity or your community.

**REQUIREMENTS**

- The project uses a Gemma 4 model through the Gemini API.
- The README names the Gemma model, and the code or demo shows the integration.

Gemma 4 is open-weight, so a Gemma project in a public GitHub repository with an open-source license can also enter Best Open-Source AI Project.

Resources: **Gemma 4 resources**, **Gemma Quickstart**, **Gemma API docs**, and the **Gemma Beginner Guide**.

**PRIZE** One winning team. Each team member from the winning team receives a gift card, so the team gets 2 to 4 gift cards. For example, if only 2 members are present, the team gets 2.

**NOTE** The organizers have the final say on how all prizes are distributed.

## 05 Hacking rules

All project work happens between the start of build time at 10:00 AM and the submission deadline at 5:00 PM.

1. You may bring an idea, including one you had before, one that has been done before, or one you worked on before. You may not bring code, designs or other project materials made before build time.
2. Ideas do not have to be new. A common idea built well is welcome.
3. You may use libraries, frameworks, public APIs, datasets, open models and open-source code. List them in your README. Open-sourcing your own earlier work just so you can use it here is not allowed.
4. Stop building at the deadline. Fixing a few lines of a bug that breaks your demo is fine; new features or large changes are not.
5. Keep your code in a public GitHub repository, and keep it public after the event. If a winner's repository goes private, the prize may go to another team.
6. Submit one project per team, and do not submit it to any other hackathon.

## 06 AI tools

AI is welcome in two different roles, and the rules differ for each. A closed AI coding assistant does not count toward the open-source AI requirement.

| AI THAT HELPS YOU BUILD | AI INSIDE YOUR PROJECT |
| --- | --- |
| **EXAMPLES**<br>Code completion, chat assistants, GitHub Copilot, image generators | **EXAMPLES**<br>An open-weight language model, an agent skill, a model harness |
| **ALLOWED?**<br>Yes, any tool | **ALLOWED?**<br>Required for the Best Open-Source AI Project challenge, and it must be open-source or open-weight |
| **WHAT YOU MUST DO**<br>List every tool in the README and the submission, say which parts it produced, and answer questions about it honestly | **WHAT YOU MUST DO**<br>Name each model, link its license or terms in the README, and show the code that uses it |

- Your project may not be a reskin of an existing AI tool. Judges look at what your team created, changed or built during the event.
- If you don't credit the AI tools you used, your team is disqualified and reported to MLH at cheating@mlh.io.

## 07 Submitting your project

**DEADLINE 5:00 PM** Every team that presents must submit through OrganizerHQ Challenges before 5:00 PM. A project that isn't in OrganizerHQ can't be judged or win.

One team member submits for the whole team:

1. Sign in with the account you used to register.
2. On the event page, select **Challenges** in the "View and submit challenges for this event" banner.
3. Select **Add Submission**. The button appears only while submissions are open.
4. Enter the project link (your public GitHub repository), the project name, a description, and the technologies used.
5. Add a demo URL if you have one. It is optional.
6. Under **Which challenge(s) are you submitting to?**, tick every challenge you are eligible for.
7. Select **Submit Project** before the deadline.

### README CHECKLIST

- [ ] What the project does and how it works
- [ ] Team members
- [ ] An open-source license file (for example `LICENSE`)
- [ ] Each open-source or open-weight model used, with a link to its license or terms
- [ ] Libraries, frameworks, APIs and datasets used
- [ ] AI coding tools used, and which parts they produced
- [ ] How to run it
- [ ] For Best Use of Gemma 4: the Gemma 4 model used, and how the project calls it through the Gemini API

When winners are announced, OrganizerHQ makes the event's project gallery public, including every submission.

## 08 Demos and judging

Every submitted team gets the same chance to demo. A panel of judges scores every eligible project on the rubric below, and the judges' decisions are final.

### DEMOS

- Time: each team gets 5 minutes to present its demo, followed by 3 minutes of questions from the judges.
- Show the working project. Pitches and slide decks are discouraged, and judges may ask to see the code.

### STEP 1: ELIGIBILITY CHECK (YES OR NO)

Your project is considered for Best Open-Source AI Project only if all of these are true:

- [ ] Every team member is a registered, checked-in student aged 18 or over
- [ ] Submitted in OrganizerHQ before 5:00 PM, with the challenge ticked
- [ ] Public GitHub repository with an open-source license
- [ ] Open-source or open-weight AI is an important part of how it works
- [ ] The README names each model and links its license or terms
- [ ] The AI tools you used are credited
- [ ] An agent skill follows the Agent Skills standard, and a harness entry is original or meaningfully changed

Best Use of Gemma 4 adds its own requirement: the project uses Gemma 4 through the Gemini API.

### STEP 2: RUBRIC

Each judge scores each eligible project from 1 to 5 on seven equally weighted criteria, for up to 35 points per judge. A project's total is the sum of every judge's scores. **MAX 35 / JUDGE**

| # | CRITERION | WHAT JUDGES ASK |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Technical implementation** | Does it work, and how well is it built for a one-day project? |
| 2 | **Use of open-source AI** | Is open-source or open-weight AI central to how it works, used well, and easy to verify through the model, license and code? |
| 3 | **Design and user experience** | Is it easy to use, and did the team think about the people using it? |
| 4 | **Creativity** | Is the idea or the implementation distinctive? |
| 5 | **Usefulness and impact** | Does it solve a clear problem or create a useful or fun experience? |
| 6 | **Learning and ambition** | What did the team learn or attempt during the event? |
| 7 | **Demo and clarity** | Can the team explain what they built, how it works, and what the AI does? |

**Not judged:** tidy or production-ready code, pitch polish, slides, or pull-request counts.

- **Ties:** the higher total for Technical implementation wins. If it's still tied, the judges vote, and the head judge decides any remaining tie.
- **Conflicts of interest:** a judge with a close relationship to a team says so and steps aside for that team.
- **No eligible project:** if no project in a challenge meets its requirements, no winner is declared for that challenge.

## 09 Fair play and disqualification

Organizers may disqualify a team for breaking these rules or the Code of Conduct, or for unsporting behaviour. Every winning project is checked before results are announced.

### WHAT ORGANIZERS CHECK

- The commit history: did work start before the event, and were changes pushed after the deadline?
- Whether the README, video or project mentions a different event
- Whether the project was submitted elsewhere or looks like an older project of the team's
- Whether each team member can explain their part, including any piece of code a judge picks
- Whether AI tools are credited

These checks prompt a closer look, not an automatic disqualification. One large commit at the end is not cheating; many beginners commit only once.

**OUTCOMES** Possible outcomes include a warning, the prize going to the next eligible team, disqualification, removal from the event for Code of Conduct breaches, and a report to MLH (cheating@mlh.io or incidents@mlh.io).